

— EDITION 34

Most “the model
is wrong” bucs
are in the data.
not the model.

I built an app to keep my household's money honest. For a while its forecast was confidently, beautifully wrong. It told us we were getting richer than we were.

0101 / 07

| The setup.

I built a small app to track our debts, accounts, recurring bills and a long-range projection. Real backend, real database, row-level security, real users. Us.

0202 / 07

| The symptom.

The forecast was confidently wrong. It told us we were getting richer than we were, by a lot, and it compounded that story out thirty years.

0303 / 07

| The hunt.

I went looking for why. The bug was in one line. Monthly surplus was income minus recurring expenses, and the recurring table only held our two paychecks. No expenses.

0404 / 07

How a small gap becomes a fantasy.

So the engine thought nearly all our income was investable surplus, then compounded the fiction for three decades. A small data gap became a six-figure fantasy.

0505 / 07

| Fix the data first.

I derived real spending from actual transactions, split true living costs from the once-a-year property-tax lump, and entered the real rows. The surplus snapped back to something honest.

0606 / 07

| Then fix the logic.

Use each debt's real interest rate instead of a hardcoded guess, and route surplus to the highest-rate debt first, the way you'd actually pay it down. Order mattered: data before logic.

0707 / 07

| Save this.

A flawless formula over garbage inputs gives you a confident wrong answer. That is more dangerous than an obvious one. Check the data before you blame the model.

— THE TAKEAWAY

Found this **useful?**

Repost to share it, and follow Joseph Bankole for field notes from shipping AI into real stacks.

◆ Joseph Bankole